

The Morning Briefing

COMPILED FOR MARCUS JOHNSON — POLITICS, LAW, CHURCH & THE WORLD

LEAD Trump's "Board of Peace" says it has a deal with Hamas on full Gaza disarmament — but neither side has confirmed it, and the sequencing fight is already visible.

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Trump Announces Gaza Disarmament Deal; Hamas, Israel Silent on Confirmation

President Trump announced Thursday night that his "Board of Peace" reached an agreement with Hamas on the "complete disarmament" of Hamas and all other armed groups in Gaza. A precise disarmament roadmap is due within 14 days; demilitarization itself is projected to take 200 to 250 days, proceeding zone by zone. Under the plan, an International Stabilization Force and a new Palestinian police force would handle security as Israeli forces withdraw "as disarmament is completed," with the stated goal of a new Palestinian government working alongside the Board of Peace.

Neither Hamas nor Israel has confirmed acceptance. A senior Hamas official has signaled that the sequencing of disarmament versus Israeli withdrawal is still contested, and Hamas says it will not implement any part of the deal if Israeli forces do not meet their own obligations. Separately, Netanyahu has said a new Gaza government is "possible" in 2026 — conditioned on Hamas disarming first.

ANALYTICAL READ

Treat the "Board of Peace" framing with the skepticism due any belligerent-brokered peace process. The plan hands Israel a phased-withdrawal trigger it alone gets to certify as satisfied. Netanyahu's condition — a government is possible "if you disarm Hamas" — is a one-way ratchet making Palestinian self-governance contingent on an outcome Israel adjudicates. Washington wants a deliverable to call historic before the midterms; Israel wants prolonged operational latitude in Gaza. That gap is where this deal is likeliest to unravel.

Jerusalem Post jpost.com/middle-east/article-904192 | **NPR** npr.org/2026/07/31/g-s1-136500/trump-hamas-gaza

Ceasefire With Iran Collapsed Weeks Ago; Kuwait, Lebanon Strikes Continue

The US-Iran ceasefire, reached April 8 and extended indefinitely by Trump on April 21, broke down in early July after both sides traded fresh strikes; Iran's Revolutionary

Guard has since blocked and diverted tankers in the Strait of Hormuz. As of July 31, Kuwait's army said it destroyed drones that entered its airspace, citing material damage from falling debris and calling the incident "Iranian aggression" against military and civilian sites in the region. Separately, the IDF said it destroyed an Iran-funded Hezbollah tunnel network in Lebanon.

ANALYTICAL READ

"Iranian aggression" is Kuwait's characterization, not an independently verified finding, and the IDF's tunnel claim comes from the IDF alone, with no outside confirmation cited. The pattern — a ceasefire that collapsed within three months, followed by strikes each side blames on the other — suggests a conflict neither side has fully committed to ending. Washington's stake is regional stability and Hormuz shipping; Israel's stake is degrading Iranian-aligned capability indefinitely. Those diverge once a new ceasefire is on the table.

Haaretz haaretz.com/israel-news/israel-security/2026-07-31 | **Wikipedia** en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_Iran_war_ceasefire

Settlers, Palestinians Clash Near Nablus a Week After Fatal Shooting

Israeli settlers entered the outskirts of Nablus in the West Bank, a week after a deadly gunfight in the nearby village of Tell. The IDF says Palestinians threw stones at the Israeli civilians and that one Israeli fired a weapon into the air.

ANALYTICAL READ

The account is sourced entirely to the IDF's characterization of a clash on Palestinian land. Who initiated contact, and why settlers were touring a West Bank village a week after a fatal shooting nearby, are questions an IDF statement will not answer.

Times of Israel timesofisrael.com/liveblog-july-31-2026

US POLITICS

House Leaves for Five Weeks; Senate Grinds on Funding, Nominations

The House has left Washington until August 31 for a district work period. The Senate stays in session through August 7, with floor time going to nominations and to drafting the Senate's version of a continuing resolution ahead of the September 30 fiscal-year deadline. This week's floor action included a motion to proceed on H.R. 5334, the Lindsey Graham Sanctioning Russia Act, and cloture on S.Res. 817, an en bloc nominations package.

WHY IT MATTERS

A five-week House recess against a Senate still grinding on a stopgap funding bill is the familiar shape of a fall shutdown fight. Watch whether the Russia sanctions bill gains momentum while the House is out.

Senate Daily Press dailypress.senate.gov | **Congress.gov** congress.gov/on-house-floor-today

CMS Set to Finalize 2027 Medicare Hospital Payment Rule

The Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services is expected to finalize the 2027 Inpatient Prospective Payment System rule by July 31, setting hospital Medicare reimbursement rates for the coming fiscal year.

National Law Review natlawreview.com/article/healthcare-preview-week-july-27-2026-podcast

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Trump, DOJ Ask SCOTUS to Toss \$83.3M Carroll Defamation Verdict

Trump's attorneys, joined separately by the Justice Department, petitioned the Supreme Court to toss the \$83.3 million defamation verdict won by E. Jean Carroll, citing presidential immunity for statements Trump made about her in 2019 while in office. The petition leans on the Court's 2024 immunity ruling, arguing the Second Circuit wrongly refused to extend that protection even though the Court held "most of a President's public communications are likely to fall comfortably within" it. The Second Circuit had affirmed the award and found Trump had previously waived any immunity claim.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the immunity doctrine's next stress test: whether it extends past official acts in office to defamatory statements about a private citizen's personal allegations. A cert grant would signal the Court is willing to keep expanding the doctrine past the 2024 ruling's core scenarios.

SCOTUSblog scotusblog.com/2026/07/trump-asks-supreme-court-to-hear-appeal | **CNN** cnn.com/2026/07/28/politics/trump-supreme-court-e-jean-carroll

Term Recap: Birthright Citizenship, Party Spending, Title IX Sports Rulings

All decided June 30: in *Trump v. Barbara*, the Court held the Constitution guarantees birthright citizenship to children born to parents unlawfully or temporarily present in the US. In *National Republican Senatorial Committee v. FEC*, the Court struck down the Federal Election Campaign Act's limits on coordinated party expenditures as a First Amendment violation. A third ruling let schools set women's and girls' sports eligibility based on biological sex.

NPR npr.org/2026/06/09/nx-s1-5847967/supreme-court-major-cases-left-2026

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Liturgy Chief: "Pope Leo Is Not Going to Change Traditionis Custodes"

Cardinal Arthur Roche, prefect of the Dicastery for Divine Worship and the Discipline of the Sacraments, told *The Tablet* in an interview published July 29 that "Pope Leo is not going to change *Traditionis Custodes*" — Pope Francis's 2021 decree restricting the pre-Vatican II Latin Mass, which requires priests to obtain their bishop's permission and confines communities attached to that liturgy to designated locations apart from ordinary parishes. Roche added Leo is "not going back to *Summorum Pontificum*," Benedict XVI's 2007 decree that had broadly permitted the older rite.

Pushing back on traditionalist objections, Roche said: "When I meet with groups who want the antecedent liturgy, and I say: Well, the Holy Father has given you that, so what's the problem?, they can't answer. But then they go away and say, We're still being persecuted. In what way

persecuted? Why is the band still playing a tune that is discordant with the life of the Church?" In January, a text Roche authored and circulated among the cardinals argued Francis "pointed the way to unity" through the restrictions and that "there ought to be only one rite for celebrating the Mass."

WHY IT MATTERS

*Roche, 76 and past normal cardinal retirement age, remains the Vatican's point man on liturgy under a new pope. This is the clearest signal yet that Leo — despite letting Cardinal Raymond Burke celebrate a Latin Mass in St. Peter's Basilica and granting two US dioceses temporary dispensations — has no intention of reopening *Traditionis Custodes*. The canonical mechanics are unchanged: priests still need episcopal permission, and the older rite stays confined outside normal parish use.*

National Catholic Reporter ncronline.org/vatican/vatican-liturgy-chief-says-pope-leo-will-not-overturn-latin-mass-restrictions

Pope Leo Wants US Visit “Within a Couple of Years”; August Schedule Set

Pope Leo XIV told NBC Nightly News and Noticias Telemundo, in interviews from the papal villa at Castel Gandolfo, that he wants to visit the United States “soon” or within a “couple of years,” though no trip is scheduled. The Vatican also released his August calendar: Masses in Assisi

and Rimini, celebrations for the Transfiguration and the Assumption of Mary, and a resumption of weekly Wednesday general audiences after suspending them for July.

UPI [upi.com/Top_News/World-News/2026/07/30/pope-leo-visit-couple-years](https://www.upi.com/Top_News/World-News/2026/07/30/pope-leo-visit-couple-years/) | **America Magazine** [americamagazine.org/news/2026/07/30/pope-leo-public-masses-audiences-august](https://www.americamagazine.org/news/2026/07/30/pope-leo-public-masses-audiences-august)

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Quranic Textual Criticism and the Historical-Critical Method

Recent Western scholarship on the Quran's textual history remains, by scholars' own admission, in its relative infancy compared to biblical criticism, constrained by the text's post-canonization stability and by the fact that serious manuscript study only accelerated in recent decades. Some historians argue the Quran as it exists today, in both form and content, took shape in the early eighth century under the Umayyad caliph Abd al-Malik rather than being fixed at the traditional mid-seventh-century date — a claim that, if sustained, would undercut the chronology Islamic orthodoxy depends on. Comparative work also traces close parallels between Quranic narratives and earlier Jewish and Christian traditions, read by some scholars as evidence of textual dependency rather than independent revelation. Historical-critical study implying human rather than divine authorship is difficult to reconcile with the faith's foundational claims, which is part of why this work has been conducted almost entirely by scholars outside the Muslim community.

ResearchGate [researchgate.net/publication/342604334](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/342604334) | **Bart Ehrman Blog** ehrmanblog.org/can-the-quran-and-early-islam-be-studied-critically

Mapping the New Right

With the old fusionist consensus of free markets, social conservatism, and hawkish foreign policy gone, a new taxonomy of right-wing factions has emerged: national conservatives, postliberals, and Claremont-aligned constitutionalists form the current coalition, absorbing currents from the online alt-right, Catholic integralism, and tech-authoritarian libertarianism. After roughly a decade of quiet coexistence, these factions have begun openly fighting each other, with religious-right and secular-right camps inside the MAGA coalition increasingly irritated by one another's priorities. Essays this year attempt to sort the resulting factions and identify which are actually driving policy versus which just generate online noise.

Persuasion persuasion.community/p/a-taxonomy-of-the-new-right | **Reason** reason.com/2026/01/30/furious-minds